THIS IS THE MOMENT INDIA SHOULD GRASP, WITH ITS **IT SERVICES FIRMS AND EAGER STARTUPS SOLVING INDIA-SPECIFIC AND GLOBAL USE CASES** ACROSS ENTERPRISES AND CONSUMERS WITH AI AGENTS AND APPLICATIONS

to 'pulling' information from computers. (AI agents will) 'push' finished work to us instead."

Thousands of startups are amping up their innovation to build agents on top of the LLMs. Genie by Gather helps parents manage their time, Minday scours the internet and mines your preferences to find the best restaurant or shop around you, and Relevance AI automates prospect meetings for harried sales reps. Klarna, a European fintech, made waves when its CEO announced that customer service agents built on Open AI platforms have 'replaced' 700 human agents and that they resolve queries in a fifth of the time it took humans. The implications for India are profound. As contact centres deal with the human agent to AI agent transition, there is a vast new opportunity for Indian startups to create agents on top of global LLMs, and Indian enterprises will be well served to understand and incorporate AI agents in their workflows.



From LLMs to Applications: This brings the old question back—does India need its own LLM? Nandan Nilekani is adamantly opposed to it, saying, "Let the big boys of the Valley do it", with India focusing on building use cases and applications on AI, rather than an LLM—a view I subscribe to. Much like the cloud, I think LLMs would be commoditised, with three or four major ones emerging as the infrastructure on which millions of apps and agents will be built. So far, most of the value in GenAI has been concentrated in the infrastructure layer, where Nvidia and the cloud providers rule; however, 2025 will see value migrate upwards to the application layer at the top which will distribute value to companies and startups innovating on top of these. This is the moment India should grasp, with its IT services firms and eager startups solving India-specific and global use cases across enterprises and consumers with AI agents and applications.

Becoming AI-literate: The definition of literacy will extend beyond reading, writing and arithmetic to using GenAI tools like ChatGPT, Perplexity and others to become more productive and efficient at work. Organisations are witnessing a new trend, BYOAI or Bring Your Own AI, where three of four employees are bringing along their own AI to work, because it helps them perform so much better (https://bit.ly/41GKJe4). Two-thirds of bosses will not hire an employee unless she has the aptitude and curiosity to work with the profusion of GenAI tools out there. Thus, it will be incumbent on managements across organisations, irrespective of sector or geography, to frame the right policies and build enablers for all their employees to become AI-literate. This is especially true in India, with a recent BCG report placing Indians among the top users of ChatGPT worldwide. We need to aspire to make every Indian AI-literate.

Doing AI Safely: As we enter the age of AI, using AI safely and responsibly will be paramount, with the ethics of AI equally, if not more, important than the technology itself. The dark side of AI is well known—privacy and surveillance, bias, deepfakes and fake news, and environmental degradation. Most countries and companies around the world are scrambling to enact regulations and guardrails around AI. India, with its large young population and its digital transformation with Digital Public Infrastructure, is well placed to lead the charge on building safe AI and bridging the digital divide by delivering it to its 1.4 billion citizens. In 2025, the Indian government should work with industry to create enforceable principles and guardrails for building and deploying AI, as well as some regulations for its known ill-effects like deepfakes. It should immediately set up a world-leading AI Safety Institute (AISI) and join the network of AISIs created worldwide, taking responsibility and leadership for AI Safety in the emerging world. Finally, the National AI Mission should extend to providing GenAI tools and technologies to every last Indian, much like UPI and Aadhaar, a concept which I call 'Jan AI'.

"AI is not just a technology or a trend," says Gartner, "it is a profound shift in the interaction between humans and machines." It is also a once-in-a-lifetime technology, and the world has the opportunity to use it wisely for prosperity and peace, or otherwise. India, with its IT prowess, startup ecosystem and openness to tech and digitisation, has a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to grasp AI and leverage it to leapfrog our dream to be a developed economy by 2047. ■

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